

Support & Resources for the AISH-to-ADAP Transition

A plain-language guide for our community

The move from AISH to ADAP has left a lot of people worried and unsure of where to turn. A community member gathered the resources below to help. They come from trusted organizations, the Canadian Mental Health Association (CMHA) and the Canadian National Institute for the Blind (CNIB). Each entry explains what the resource is, who it can help, and how to reach it.

A quick note on the short forms: AISH is the Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped program, and ADAP is the Alberta Disability Assistance Program.

If you are struggling right now, you are not alone

9-8-8 — Suicide Crisis Helpline. Call or text 9-8-8, free, any time, day or night.

2-1-1 — Call or text 2-1-1 any time to be connected to the right help, including help understanding AISH and ADAP.

Distress Line (Edmonton area) — Call 780-482-HELP (4357), 24 hours a day.

If someone is in immediate danger, call 9-1-1 and stay with them.

1. Free plain-language course: Understanding AISH & ADAP

From: CMHA Edmonton

A free, plain-language course for people with disabilities, caregivers, and support workers navigating the change to ADAP. It walks through the differences between AISH and ADAP, who qualifies, benefit amounts, health coverage, income and asset rules, how to apply, how to work with your doctor on a strong medical report, what happens after you apply, and how appeals work. It also covers reporting income, the Disability Tax Credit and Canada Disability Benefit, and budgeting on a limited income.

Upcoming 2026 dates: In person (CMHA Edmonton, 10232 – 106 St NW, Room E125): Monday, July 13, 6–9 p.m.; and Thursday, August 13, 1–4 p.m. Online by Zoom: Monday, July 20, 10 a.m. – 1 p.m.

To register: visit the CMHA Edmonton AISH & ADAP page (edmonton.cmha.ca/aish-changes26) or the Recovery College (recoverycollegeedmonton.ca). The same page links to a free written guide and the government's AISH and ADAP Benefit Estimator.

2. Free one-on-one peer support

From: CMHA Edmonton

Peer support workers are people who understand what you are going through and can help you take the next step. They can help with financial-assistance applications and appeals, referrals to free or low-cost counselling, support for family members and caregivers, finding affordable housing and subsidies, landlord and tenant issues, and connecting to recovery programs, education, or job training. You can meet in person, by phone, or by email.

Hours: Monday to Friday, 8:30 a.m. – 4:30 p.m. (closed statutory holidays). **To connect:** call 2-1-1 and ask for Peer Services. If you are in crisis, call the 24/7 Distress Line at 780-482-HELP (4357).

3. Help by phone, any time: 2-1-1 Alberta

From: CMHA / 211 Alberta

You can call or text 2-1-1 at any time, day or night, for free. The people who answer have a lot of experience helping Albertans understand and navigate the AISH and ADAP process, and they can connect you to other supports in your area.

4. If the changes are affecting your mental health

From: CMHA Alberta Division and the Centre for Suicide Prevention

CMHA Alberta has publicly recognized that the changes to AISH are causing real worry and distress for many people living with disabilities, and has said clearly that support is available and that no one has to face these feelings alone. If you are struggling, you can talk to someone you trust, a loved one, your doctor, or a counsellor, or call or text 9-8-8 any time.

CMHA has offices across Alberta, including Edmonton, Calgary, Red Deer, Lethbridge, Camrose, Grande Prairie, and Fort McMurray, where you can talk to someone and get help. CMHA Edmonton also offers grief support sessions for people affected by a suicide loss in the community. Find your local office at cmha.ca/find-help.

5. Employment support for people with sight loss: Come to Work

From: CNIB (Canadian National Institute for the Blind)

If you have sight loss and are looking for work, or being asked to look for work, Come to Work is a free program that connects people who are blind or have low vision with employers and mentors. It includes a talent pool you can join, mentorship, and events. CNIB partners with many large Canadian employers, and the program receives funding through the governments of Canada and Alberta. It offers a supportive, informed alternative for people navigating employment expectations.

Learn more or join: cometowork.ca, see “Find Work” to join the talent pool.

6. Free legal referrals for people with sight loss

From: CNIB Legal Referral Service

A free, confidential service that helps people with sight loss get connected to community legal services and organizations that fit their situation. Staff will talk with you about your issue and point you toward the right legal help, or provide resources in an accessible format.

Please note: CNIB does not give legal advice or act as your lawyer, and cannot guarantee the services of other organizations. It is a referral and navigation service, a starting point, and it is not for emergencies.

To reach them: call 1-800-563-2642, Monday to Thursday, 10 a.m. – 3 p.m. Eastern (closed Fridays; Thursdays close about 2:25 p.m.). You can also fill out the Legal Referral Request Form online. Replies can take up to three business days. More: cnib.ca/en/legal-referral-service.

7. Bigger-picture advocacy: the Mental Health Parity Act

From: CMHA National

This one is background reading rather than a direct service. CMHA supports a proposed federal law, the Mental Health Parity Act (Bill C-280), that would bring mental health, addictions, and substance use care into Canada's public health-care system, treating mental health care as essential health care, the same as physical health care. It is part of the larger push to make sure care is available based on need, not on ability to pay.

Shared by The Alberta Disability System Breakdown. These resources were gathered by a community member and point to outside organizations that we are not affiliated with. Program details such as dates, hours, and phone numbers can change, so please confirm with each organization before you rely on them. For official AISH and ADAP information, visit alberta.ca.

This guide mentions suicide and mental-health distress. If any of it brings up difficult feelings, please reach out, call or text 9-8-8 or 2-1-1 any time. You deserve support.